

Steve Jobs' Commencement Speech at Stanford University

I am honored to be with you today at your commencement from one of the finest universities in the world. I never graduated from college; in fact, this is the closest I have ever come to a college graduation. Today, I would like to share three stories from my life. That's all—nothing too complicated, just three simple stories.

The first story is about connecting the dots.

I dropped out of Reed College after just six months, but I stayed on unofficially for about eighteen more months before leaving for good. Why did I drop out?

The story actually begins before I was born. My biological mother was a young, unmarried graduate student who decided to put me up for adoption. She strongly believed that I should be adopted by college graduates, and arrangements were made for me to be adopted by a lawyer and his wife. However, when I was born, they decided at the last minute that they wanted a girl instead. My adoptive parents, who were on a waiting list, received a call in the middle of the night asking if they would take an unexpected baby boy. They said yes.

Later, my biological mother discovered that my adoptive mother had not graduated from college and my adoptive father had not finished high school. She initially refused to sign the adoption papers, but eventually agreed after my parents promised that I would attend college someday.

Seventeen years later, I did go to college. However, I chose a school that was nearly as expensive as Stanford, and my working-class parents were spending all their savings on my tuition. After six months, I couldn't see the value in continuing. I didn't know what I wanted to do with my life, and I didn't see how college would help me figure it out. Meanwhile, I was using up all the money my parents had saved over their entire lives. So I decided to drop out and trust that things would somehow work out. It was a frightening decision at the time, but looking back, it turned out to be one of the best decisions I ever made.

Once I dropped out, I no longer had to take required classes that didn't interest me. Instead, I could focus on subjects that truly fascinated me. It wasn't an easy life—I didn't have a dorm room, so I slept on friends' floors. I collected Coke bottles for the five-cent deposits to buy food, and I walked seven miles across town every Sunday night to get a good meal at the Hare Krishna temple. Despite the hardships, I loved it.

Many of the things I discovered by following my curiosity and intuition later proved to be incredibly valuable. For example, Reed College offered one of the best calligraphy programs in the country. The campus was filled with beautifully crafted typography—posters, labels, and signs were all hand-lettered with great care. Since I wasn't bound by

a formal schedule, I decided to take a calligraphy class.

In that class, I learned about serif and sans-serif typefaces, spacing between letters, and what makes typography visually appealing. It was artistic, historical, and subtle in ways that science cannot easily explain. I found it deeply fascinating.